

Multivoicedness and Moral Injury: Understanding Identity Disruption and Restoration in First Responders

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BACKGROUND

- Moral injury refers to psychological distress arising from violating or witnessing violations of deeply held moral values (Cahill et al., 2023)
- High-risk professions (e.g., first responders) are particularly vulnerable due to:

- Exposure to morally challenging situations
- Pressure to act, fail to act, or witness harm (Magen et al., 2025)

Associated outcomes include:

- Guilt, shame, and social withdrawal
- Anxiety, depression, PTSD symptoms, and burnout
- Impaired functioning (Magen et al., 2025)

Moral Injury and Identity

- Moral injury disrupts identity and self-concept
- Professional identities are grounded in moral values:
 - Fairness
 - Responsibility
 - Altruism (Carminati & Gao Hélot, 2021; Hodges et al., 2025)
- When actions conflict with these values:
 - Individuals experience internal dissonance
 - Sense of self becomes destabilized (Hodges et al., 2025)

Theoretical Framework

- From a dialogical perspective, the self is composed of multiple interacting voices shaped through social relationships and recognition by others (Atkins, 2008; Aveling et al., 2014).
- Moral injury may therefore reflect a disruption in this dialogical system, where conflicting identity voices create internal tension and fragmentation.

Research Focus

This study examines how conflicts among internal identity voices contribute to moral injury and how supportive voices may facilitate identity restoration and moral repair.

Research Questions

- What I-positions and inner-Others voices emerge, and how do they interact?
- How do conflicts between internal identity voices relate to moral injury?
- How do these interactions between voices shape moral failure, identity disruption, and identity restoration?

METHODS

Methodology

Approach: Qualitative coding of identity-based voice conflicts in moral injury narratives

Data Source:

- 3 life-story interviews with first responders
- Participants from *Valhalla Project Niagara* (Canadian PTSD support organization; Arnoldi, 2023)

Focus of Interviews:

- Life experiences
- Meaning-making processes
- Personal histories

Analysis Process:

- All transcripts coded
- Collaborative comparison to ensure consistency

Analytical Outcome:

Identify patterns of:

- Voice conflict → moral injury & identity disruption
- Supportive/recognizing voices → identity restoration

Analytical Framework: Multivoicedness (Aveling et al., 2014)

Step 1: I-positions (Self voices)

Code first-person pronouns (e.g., *I, we, my*)
Cluster into identity positions
e.g., *I-as-first responder, I-as-helper*

Step 2: Inner-Others (External voices)

Code references to others (e.g., family, institutions)
Identify through:

- Third-person references
- Direct/indirect quotations
- Broader social discourses

Step 3: Dialogical Interactions

Examine relationships between voices:

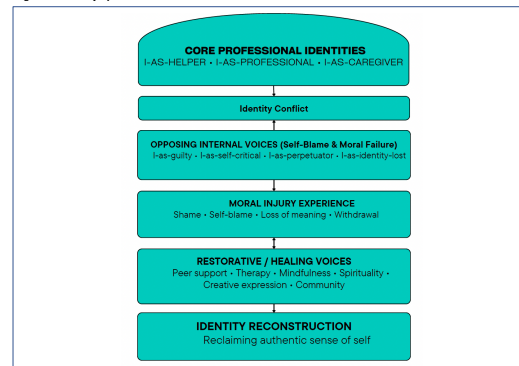
- I-position ↔ I-position
 - I-position ↔ inner-Other
- Identify tensions ("dialogical knots") indicating identity conflict

RESULTS

Table 1: Identity Voice Conflicts in Moral Injury

Theme	Identity Voices (I-Positions)	Opposing Voices	Example Evidence	Interpretation
Moral Identity Violation	I-as-helper, I-as-professional, I-as-caregiver	I-as-guilty, I-as-perpetrator, I-as-self-critical	"From 'Helping people is very meaningful for me. Being a mom and being a good person are most meaningful for me.' to 'I essentially tortured a lot of people... it's my hands.'"	Moral injury emerges when valued helping identities conflict with voices of guilt and failure
Erosion of Professional Self-Efficacy	I-as-competent, I-as-confident, I-as-leader	I-as-inadequate, I-as-self-doubting, I-as-failure	From "And I worked well under stress. That was like my thing... I became a nurse and graduated at the top of my class" to "I probably wasn't the greatest nurse... And I did not sign up to hurt people."	Repeated exposure to moral stress shifts identity from competence to inadequacy, eroding professional self-worth
Disruption of Meaning and Purpose	I-as-purpose-driven, I-as-contributor, I-as-passionate professional	I-as-meaningless, I-as-disconnected, I-as-hopeless	From "When I joined the fire department, I felt like 'Finally, I had found my purpose, my meaning in life, my passion.' to '75% of the time it was a fog... meaningless.'"	Traumatic events disrupt continuity of purpose, leading to existential disorientation and loss of meaning
Social Disconnection and Identity Isolation	I-as-community member, I-as-supported, I-as-family member	I-as-isolated, I-as-outcast, I-as-socially disconnected	From "I worked with all of them, and I got along with all of them, and made a lot of friends, and you know life was good, and thanks for progressing" to "I just stayed at home... more and more isolated."	Social withdrawal reflects internal dominance of disconnection voices, reinforcing moral injury

Figure 1: Moral Injury Voice Conflict Model



Moral Injury as Identity-Based Voice Conflict

- Moral injury emerged as conflicts between core identity positions
- Participants shifted between:
 - Valued identities:** *I-as-helper, I-as-professional, I-as-caregiver*
 - Opposing voices:** *I-as-perpetrator, I-as-guilty, I-as-self-critical, I-as-identity-lost*
- These tensions reflect dialogical struggles within the self (Table 1)
- Outcomes:
 - Persistent shame, self-blame, responsibility
 - Destabilization of moral identity
- Therefore, moral injury can be understood as an identity-based disruption

Trauma and Loss of Meaning

- Shift from **meaning-oriented identities** → **disrupted self-states**
 - From: *helper, contributor, passionate professional*
 - To: *hopeless, isolated, disconnected*
- Participants reported:
 - Loss of purpose
 - Feeling "lost" or burdened
- This indicates breakdown in meaning-making and identity coherence (Table 1)

Model of Moral Injury (Figure 1)

- Stage 1:** Core identities encounter conflicting internal voices
- Stage 2:** Emergence of:
 - Shame, guilt, self-blame
 - Loss of meaning
 - Social withdrawal
- Stage 3:** Intervention of restorative voices:
 - Peer support, therapy, mindfulness, community
- Stage 4:** Identity reconstruction:
 - Rebuilding meaning
 - Restoring coherent sense of self
- Moral injury is a dynamic, ongoing dialogical process

Identity Restoration Through Supportive Voices

Recovery linked to emergence of **restorative voices** (Table 2):

- Community connection
- Therapy
- Spirituality & mindfulness
- Creative expression
- Supports development of new identities:
 - I-as-restored self*
 - I-as-supported*
 - I-as-expressive*
- Outcomes:
 - Reframing trauma
 - Rebuilding meaning
 - Reclaiming identity coherence and agency

Table 2: Identity Restoration through Multivoicedness Processes in Moral Injury

Theme	Restorative Identity Voices (I-Positions)	Supporting Voices (Inner-Others)	Example Evidence	Interpretation
Relational Recognition and Validation	I-as-recognized, I-as-understood, I-as-valued, I-as-minfulness	Voice of Peers, children, therapists, supportive community	"The biggest thing for me was meeting other people that had been through some more experiences and felt the same way as me... I met these people, and they're saying these things to me. And I'm like, Okay, it's not just me. And I'm not crazy."	Recognition from others re-establishes a sense of legitimacy and counteracts internalized self-doubt
Reclaiming Agency and Control	I-as-agentic, I-as-capable, I-as-reclaiming-self, I-as-daily achieve, I-as-coping, I-as-managing, I-as-active-coper, I-as-boundary-setting	Voice of therapy, self-reflective dialogue	"So I gotta live, do smaller goals. So every day I pick something, something I have to complete or something I have to get done, or something I want to improve. And that's just like those small everyday goals. That's what I do."	Small acts of action signal restoration of control and re-engagement with life
Reconnection to Valued Roles	I-as-hateful, I-as-caring self, I-as-mentor, I-as-expressive-meaning-maker	Voice of peers, caregiving relationships	"I actually built a little chair for my grandson, so I can't wait to show it to him."	Re-engaging with caring roles restores alignment with core values

DISCUSSION

General Implications

Moral injury can be understood as:

- An identity-based conflict of internal voices
- Not solely a reaction to traumatic events

Intervention Implications

Effective support should focus on:

- Separating personal responsibility from systemic failure
- Reducing self-blame and shame
- Supporting reconstruction of valued identity positions

Organizational Implications

Institutions play a critical role in shaping outcomes:

- Invalidation → intensifies moral injury
- Recognition & support → facilitates recovery

Key Takeaway

According to the three participants' experiences:

- Moral injury emerges when:
 - Core identity voices conflict with voices of guilt, failure, and self-blame

Healing begins when:

- Supportive voices are introduced
- Individuals can reconstruct a coherent, meaningful sense of self

REFERENCES

Scan to see the references



This study is being conducted by a master's student enrolled in an OISE program. This study is not run by or affiliated with OISE and OISE does not endorse this poster.



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